

MASTER OF CEREMONIES
(from left) Tejashwi Yadav, Mallikarjun Kharge, Rahul Gandhi and Nitish Kumar in New Delhi on April 12

ANI

There seems to be a shift in Kejriwal's tone too—Nitish met him a day after his meeting with Rahul and Kharge. After the meeting, the Delhi CM, who has not been on great terms with the Congress, told the media that he was "completely with Nitish" and that it was "extremely necessary" for the opposition to "come together and change the government at the Centre". For its part, the Congress, too, is apparently warming up to Kejriwal, considering how Kharge telephoned him to express solidarity after the CBI recently summoned him in the liquor policy case.

THE ELECTORAL MATH

Nitish and some leaders feel that despite its meteoric rise, the BJP can still be cornered as it does not have a pan-India imprint yet. At the peak of its popularity in the 2019 Lok Sabha election, 87 per cent of the 303 seats the saffron side won came from just 12 states: Uttar Pradesh, Madhya Pradesh, Gujarat, Karnataka, Rajasthan, Maharashtra, West Bengal, Bihar, Jharkhand, Haryana, Assam and Chhattisgarh. While the BJP got at least 10 seats in each of these states, opposition parties formed governments in five of them.

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In state elections, Maharashtra and Karnataka have demonstrated that a combined effort can bear fruit. In Maharashtra in 2019, the erstwhile Shiv Sena came together with former adversaries Congress and the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), to form a government under the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) banner. In Karnataka, H.D. Kumaras-